

## Turkmenistan

 Only two per cent of Turkmenistan's arid land can be farmed. With irrigation, cotton, fruit, wheat, and vegetables are produced. Many people live in nomadic tribes, and there is much intertribal tension. Turkmenistan is the world's fifth largest producer of natural gas.



Saddlecloths



Akhal-Teke

**Akhal-Teke**  
Known as the "wind of heaven", Akhal-Teke race-horses have been bred in the south of the Karakumy Desert for centuries. Fast, hardy, and well suited to the hot, harsh climate, Akhal-Tekes compete in traditional horse races at the Ashgabat hippodrome.

### Carpets

For centuries, Turkmenistan has produced beautiful, velvety carpets in deep, toning shades of red, brown, and maroon. Women hand-knot each carpet using fine wool from karakul sheep. They make several sizes, including *khali* (large), *ensi* (door rug), as well as weaving curtains, sacks, bags, and pouches.

### TURKMENISTAN FACTS

|                |                                  |
|----------------|----------------------------------|
| CAPITAL CITY   | Ashgabat                         |
| AREA           | 488,100 sq km (188,455 sq miles) |
| POPULATION     | 4,500,000                        |
| MAIN LANGUAGES | Turkmen, Russian                 |
| MAJOR RELIGION | Muslim                           |
| CURRENCY       | Manat                            |

## Uzbekistan

 Although 80 per cent of Uzbekistan is covered by dry steppe and desert, its areas of fertile land and resources of oil, gas, gold, copper, and coal make it one of Central Asia's wealthier countries. Fruit, silk cocoons, and vegetables are exported to Moscow. Uzbekistan has the world's largest single gold mine.



### Cotton

Uzbekistan is the world's fourth largest producer of cotton. However, the irrigation system used to water crops has seriously depleted the Aral Sea.

### UZBEKISTAN FACTS

|                |                                  |
|----------------|----------------------------------|
| CAPITAL CITY   | Tashkent                         |
| AREA           | 447,400 sq km (172,741 sq miles) |
| POPULATION     | 24,300,000                       |
| MAIN LANGUAGES | Uzbek, Russian                   |
| MAJOR RELIGION | Muslim                           |
| CURRENCY       | Som                              |

The Tilya-Kari is an Islamic seminary in Registan Square.

An intricate mosaic covers building.



### Samarkand

Home to 370,000 people, the ancient city of Samarkand was once the centre for trade in silk from China. Today, the manufacture of silk and cotton textiles is still the city's main industry. Samarkand's Registan Square contains some magnificent 14th-century Islamic architecture.

## Kyrgyzstan

 Dominated by the arid Tian Shan mountains, Kyrgyzstan is a mainly rural country. Only seven per cent of the land is cultivable. Half is used for growing fodder for livestock; the rest supports vegetables, wheat, fruit, cotton, and tobacco.

### People

The population of Kyrgyzstan is made up of 57 per cent Kyrgyz people. The rest are mainly Russians and Uzbeks. Many Russians are leaving as a result of the strong nationalist feelings that have grown in the country since the end of Soviet rule. Ethnic tension also exists with the Uzbeks.



Gold

### Resources

Gold and mercury are mined for export, as well as smaller amounts of other minerals, including iron ore, tin, lead, copper, zinc, and bauxite. Kyrgyzstan also has reserves of oil, coal, and gas, and its many rivers and lakes give it great potential for hydroelectric power.

## Tajikistan

 The poorest of the former Soviet republics, Tajikistan has been torn by civil war ever since independence. The main conflict is between ethnic Tajiks, who make up about two-thirds of the population, and Uzbeks, who make up one-quarter. Tajikistan has rich mineral resources.



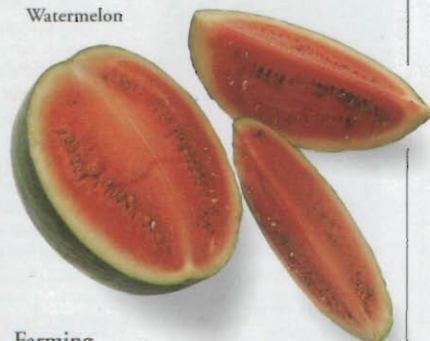
### Uranium

Tajikistan has 14 per cent of the world's uranium, used as nuclear fuel. It is a major export, but the end of the nuclear arms race has reduced its value.

### TAJIKISTAN FACTS

|                |                                 |
|----------------|---------------------------------|
| CAPITAL CITY   | Dushanbe                        |
| AREA           | 143,100 sq km (55,251 sq miles) |
| POPULATION     | 6,200,000                       |
| MAIN LANGUAGES | Tajik, Uzbek                    |
| MAJOR RELIGION | Muslim                          |
| CURRENCY       | Somoni                          |

### Watermelon



### Farming

Only about six per cent of Tajikistan is suitable for farming. The main farming areas are in the northwest, near Khudzhand, and the southwest, south of Dushanbe. Melons, grapes, and peaches are grown in fertile soils washed down from the mountains into the valleys.

## Afghanistan

 Afghanistan has a long history of war. After years of civil strife, Afghanistan was further destroyed by a US-led 'war on terrorism' in 2001-02. Pashtuns are the majority ethnic group. Afghanistan is one of the world's poorest countries.



### Taliban

An Islamic sect called the Taliban took power in 1996 and created a hardline regime which banned many freedoms. Women suffered heavily under Taliban rule as they were forbidden to receive an education, hold a job, or show their faces in public. The Taliban fled power in 2001 during western war reprisals for the September 11 terrorist attacks.

### AFGHANISTAN FACTS

|                |                                  |
|----------------|----------------------------------|
| CAPITAL CITY   | Kabul                            |
| AREA           | 652,090 sq km (251,770 sq miles) |
| POPULATION     | 26,800,000                       |
| MAIN LANGUAGES | Persian, Pashto                  |
| MAJOR RELIGION | Muslim                           |
| CURRENCY       | Afghani                          |

FIND OUT  
MORE

ASIA,  
HISTORY OF

DESERTS

FARMING

HORSES

ISLAM

MOUNTAINS  
AND VALLEYS

NUCLEAR  
POWER

ROCKS AND  
MINERALS

TEXTILES  
AND WEAVING

TRADE AND  
INDUSTRY